so attract the attention of the Western media. China's spying in America is so pervasive and endemic that current FBI director Christopher Wray has called it the most significant long-term threat the country faces, stating that Beijing has placed spies in scores of American universities and research institutes across the country.[39]

Economic and political espionage are just part of China's global strategy. Much of China's newfound wealth, whether gained lawfully or illicitly, has been poured into the gleaming, futuristic cities that now dot its landscape, and into the pockets of its political and economic elites, who buy up prime property in Los Angeles, New York, and Hong Kong. Yet just as much wealth has gone into increasing China's national power and dramatically modernizing its military. Just a few decades ago, China's army was based on 1950s weaponry, while its navy was a coastal patrol force and its air force was far outclassed by that of tiny Taiwan. Today, in terms of both quantity and quality, the PLA is second only to the armed forces of the United States. That military, and how Beijing is using it, comprises another of the new rules by which the country is protecting its interests, often at the expense of other nations.

Perhaps more important than building bigger, more powerful armed forces, which all nations do when they have the money, is the type of armed forces Beijing is building. From hypersonic weapons to aircraft carriers, and from antisatellite capabilities to nuclear missiles and cyberattack capabilities, China has invested in a military that far outstrips those of any of its neighbors. Specifically, the modernized PLA appears designed to target the strengths of US forces in Asia. Beijing has used stolen information on the US Air Force's F-22 and F-35 stealth fighters to build copycat versions that can outduel planes of neighboring states and challenge older US aircraft such as the F-15 and F-16. It also has invested heavily in attack submarines and Asia's largest surface combatant vessels, and its new aircraft carrier, along with three other currently planned carriers, will one day be able to project Chinese power throughout the waters of the Indo-Pacific region. The Chinese navy now has approximately 400 vessels and could reach as many as